Report

Introduction

In the context of the evaluation of the Monitoring and Evaluation Certification Programme 2025, with the aim of obtaining data for the final evaluation, 215 participants were reached and asked to answer a questionnaire designed to assess their expectations regarding the programme and their experience of M&E in their organizations.

The questionnaire was divided into three sections, for a total of 29 items with closed-ended or open-ended responses.

In the first section, “Participants’ Profile,” socio-demographic data were collected, focusing on educational and professional background (e.g., “I am currently working for a …”; “Please briefly describe your current professional responsibilities [and relate them to this course]”).

In the second section, “Participants’ Experience,” questions were designed to collect data on participants’ perceptions of the field of M&E from their perspective (e.g., “How often do you refer to the project periodic work plans and budget during project implementation?”) and on-the-job challenges related to its planning and implementation (e.g., “What is the main problem that you experience in relation to project and programme monitoring and evaluation in general?”).

In the third section, “Participants’ Expectations,” the questions aimed to collect data on participants’ expectations of the Certification Programme and on the use of the competencies acquired through it (e.g., “What are your main expectations from this Monitoring and Evaluation training/certification programme?”).

Aims of the report

The topics of the present report are the hedonic evaluation—in terms of positive/negative experience—of M&E processes and practices that participants have experienced in their careers, as well as the competencies and skills they expected to develop during the programme.

More specifically, three aims were identified:

- To assess whether there is a relationship between participants’ gender and their hedonic evaluation of their experience with M&E, addressing the question:
    - Is there a gender dimension (Q01), or a relationship with participants’ experience in evaluation (Q23)?
- To assess whether there is a relationship between participants’ current employing organization and the type and overall frequency of risk management practices, addressing the question:
    - Is there a link between participants’ type of organization (Q03) and their use of risk management processes (Q20)?

- Finally, participants were asked to identify three skills that they wished to acquire through the certification programme, with the item:
  - Identify the three main skills that participants wish to acquire through the certification programme (Q27).

Sample

The sample is composed of 216 alumni of the 2025 M&E Certification Programme (cohort unknown), the majority of whom are female (64.6%), are between 30 and 39 years old (43.3%), hold a master's degree (74.3%), and have between 5 and 10 years of work experience (31.2%).

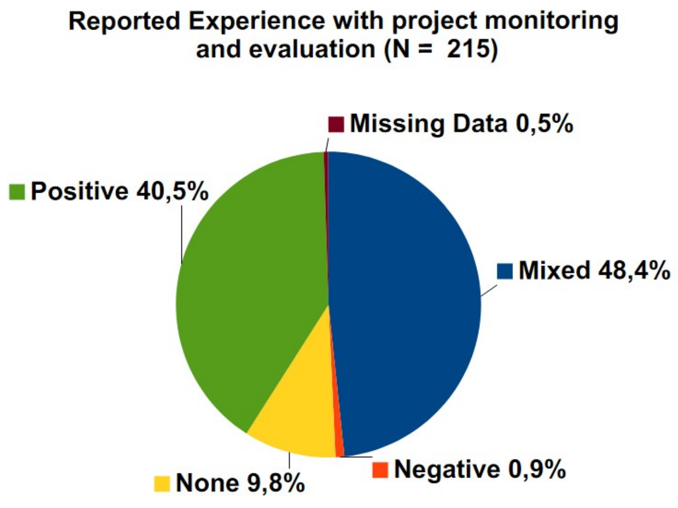
One participant did not answer any questions and was therefore excluded from the analysis.

Perception of own experience in M&E

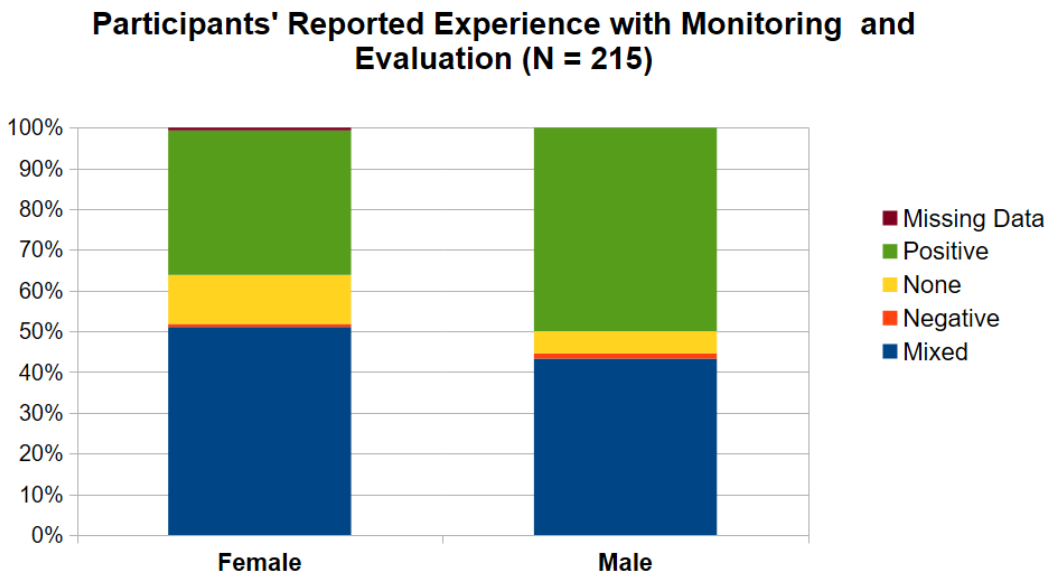
The answers provided by participants show that, overall, participants report a mixed (n = 104, 48.4%) or positive (n = 87, 40.5%) experience with M&E. The group reporting no experience (n = 21, 9.8%) and negative experience (n = 2, 0.9%) accounts for a small minority of the sample and was therefore excluded from subsequent analyses.

Gender	In general, my experience with project monitoring and evaluation has been:					
Gender	**Mixed**	**Negative**	**None**	**Positive**	**Missing Data**	**Rows totals**
Female	72	1	17	50	1	141
Male	32	1	4	37		74
Totals	**104**	**2**	**21**	**87**	**1**	**215**

Female participants more often report a mixed experience (n = 72, 33.48%) compared to a positive one (n = 50, 23.25%). The opposite pattern is observed among male participants, although with a small difference, suggesting that men report somewhat more positive experiences (n = 37, 17.20%) than mixed experiences (n = 32, 14.88%). A small minority of participants report having no experience (n = 21, 9.8%) or a negative experience (n = 2, 0.9%)



To understand whether the difference between positive and mixed experiences could be driven by gender differences, it is useful to compare the distribution of evaluations across the two groups. In proportion to the sample size, in the female subsample a larger proportion of participants tend to report a mixed experience of M&E. In the male subsample, the difference between positive and mixed experiences appears smaller.



To account quantitatively for these differences, a chi-square test of independence was performed to examine the relationship between gender and experience in evaluation, considering only positive and mixed experiences. The relationship between these variables was not significant and overall weak ($\chi^2_{(1,\ n\ =\ 191)}$ = 2.84, p = .092, Cramér's V = 0.12). To further investigate, a binomial test was conducted to assess whether the difference between mixed and positive experiences in M&E was statistically significant within each group. Results for female participants indicated that the observed proportion of .59 (k = 72, n = 122) was significantly different from the expected .50 (p =

.043). Results for the male group showed that the observed proportion of .54 (k = 37, n = 69) was not significantly different from the expected .50 (p = .628).

In conclusion, based on the analyses, it can be said that men and women do not differ significantly in reporting a positive or mixed experience in M&E, and that in the female subsample there is a slight tendency to report mixed experiences.

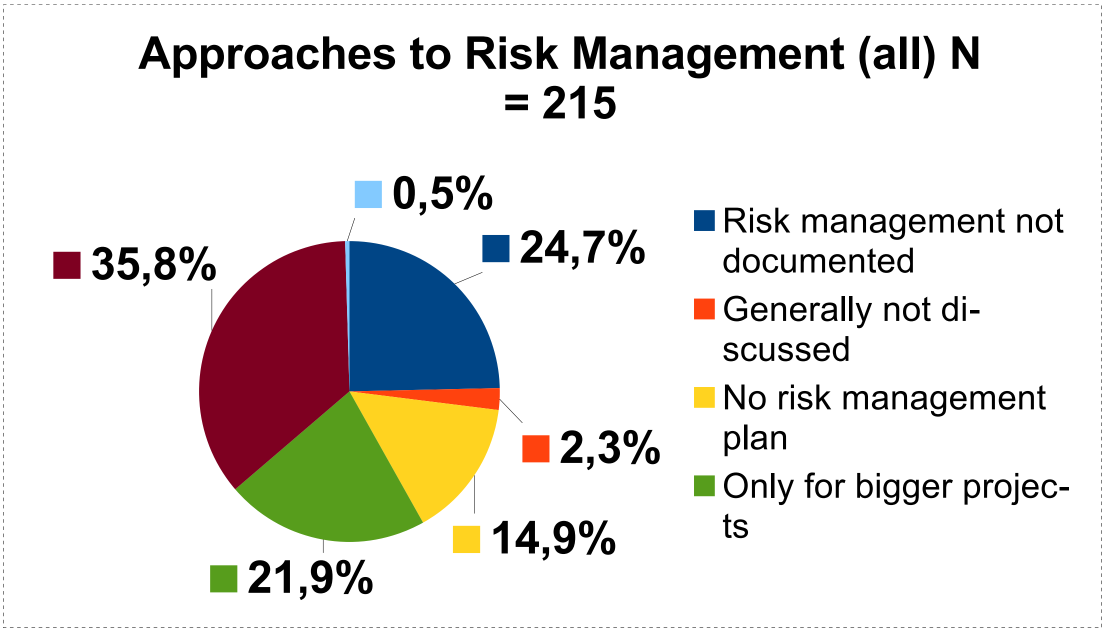
Organization of affiliation and risk management

Regarding organizational affiliation and risk management practices, results show that among participants (N = 215), the majority report a systematic approach to risk management within their organization, including the preparation of a project risk plan, a risk management strategy, and ongoing monitoring (n = 77, 35.8%).

The next most represented categories are organizations where a risk management plan and risk monitoring are prepared only for larger projects (n = 47, 21.9%) and organizations where risk is discussed but the process is not documented (n = 53, 24.7%).

These are followed by organizations where risk is discussed but there is no formal risk management plan, and adaptation occurs during the implementation phase (n = 35, 14.9%), and by a small number of cases where risk is not discussed because the project is not perceived as facing any risk (n = 5, 2.3%).

Risk management plan: At work, when preparing for project implementation:							
Professional background	**Risk management not documented**	**Generally not discussed**	**No risk manage ment plan**	**Only for bigger projects**	**Systematic approach to risk**	**Missing data**	**Rows Totals**
Government/ Public	8		10	10	10		38
NGO	16	1	8	14	15	1	55
Other type	7	2	6	8	17		40
Private sector	12		3	3	6		24
Trade Union/Employer	1				1		2
Training/ academic	4	1	2	1	4		12
UN	5	1	3	11	24		44
Totals	**53**	**5**	**32**	**47**	**77**	**1**	**215**

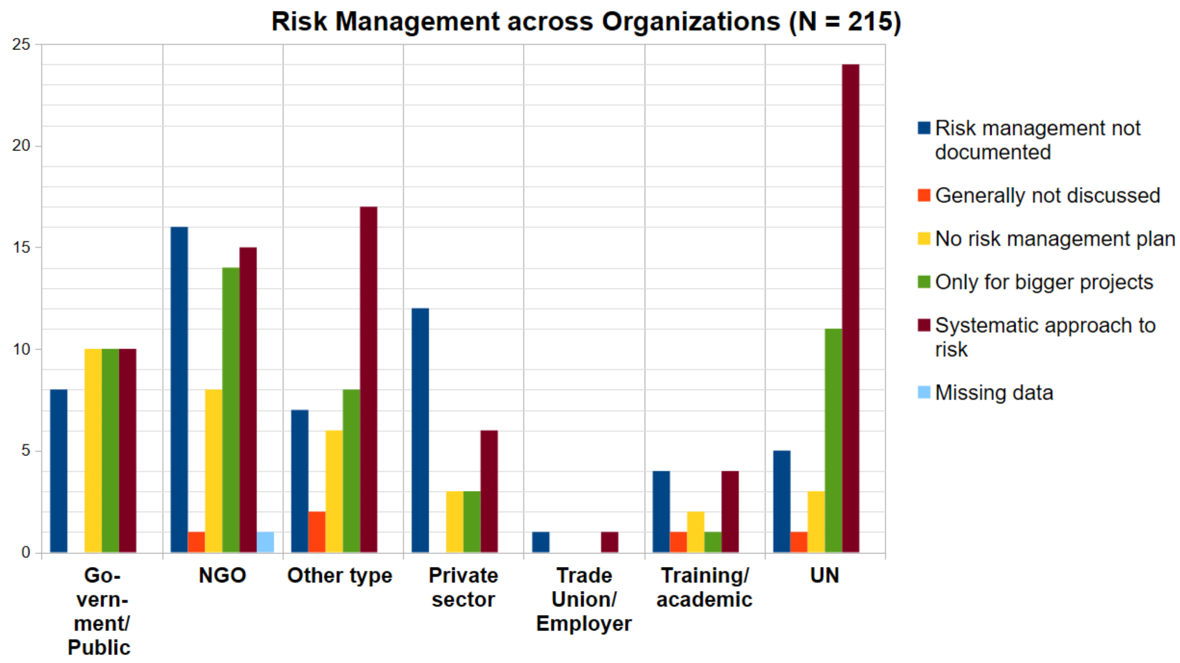


Among organizations, it clearly emerges that when participants belong to UN organizations (n = 44, 20.5%), the most frequently reported approach to risk is systematic and thorough, or, to a lesser extent, applied only to larger projects.A similar pattern is observed in private sector companies (n = 24, 11.2%), although to a lesser extent.

Government and public institutions (n = 38, 17.7%) tend to show an approach to risk that is more evenly distributed across the absence of a risk management plan, partial documentation of risk, planning only for larger projects, and a systematic approach to risk.

For non-governmental organizations, which represent the largest group of participants (n = 55, 25.6%), the most common approaches are discussing risk without documenting it, a systematic approach, and an approach limited to larger projects.

Among participants from other types of organizations (mainly international organizations or consultancies; n = 40, 18.6%), the most frequently reported approach is a systematic approach to risk.



Finally, for other organizational types, the data show a clearer pattern only for the private sector (n = 24, 11.2%), where the most represented approach is discussing risk without documenting it. For trade unions or employer organizations (n = 2, 0.9%) and training or academic institutions (n = 12, 5.6%), the data are limited, but a systematic approach and a lack of documentation appear to be the most represented.

Three main skills that participants wish to acquire through the certification programme

Participants were asked to provide an answer to an open-ended question about the three main skills they wish to acquire through the certification programme.

To identify the most frequently mentioned skills, the data were subjected to qualitative analysis in subsequent phases.

In the first stage, given the nature of the question, a deductive approach was applied. Before reviewing the responses, a set of categories was defined based on considerations about the nature of the programme. This process led to the identification of an initial set of categories, which were used during the first round of coding, namely:

- Data analysis skills (e.g., “skills in data analysis”)
- Project design skills (e.g., “improved project design; understanding all components of a logical framework, with a focus on assumptions; assessing the evaluability of a project”)
- Evaluation skills (e.g., “how to evaluate”)

- Monitoring skills (e.g., "how to monitor")
- Project implementation skills (e.g., "learning about the different requirements, legal or otherwise, to consider when proposing the implementation of a programme")
- Project monitoring skills (e.g., "to monitor and evaluate project work and decisions")

After the first round of coding, it was noted that in most cases participants were not precise or specific in defining skills. Most responses referred to broad categories rather than clearly defined individual skills. Therefore, to avoid introducing excessive subjectivity into the analysis, responses were coded at the level of broader categories representing groups of skills (e.g., "designing and applying results-based monitoring frameworks: strengthening my ability to formulate indicators, assumptions, and risks, and to link outputs, outcomes, and impacts through a coherent logic model").

To preserve the original level of abstraction in the data and avoid overly subjective interpretation, rather than adding new categories or excessively refining existing ones (inductive approach), categories at different levels of abstraction were retained.

The categories added, with examples, were:

- Leadership: "Project leadership and decision-making using M&E"
- Data management: "But also good data management [...]"
- Data collection: "But also good data management and analysis"
- Data evaluation: "Ensure data quality"
- Transforming data into actionable insights: "How to translate M&E into actionable improvements to a project"
- Reporting: "How to present results"
- Communication: "Clarity in communicating M&E requirements"
- Persuasion: "Skills to persuade colleagues to include targets in logframes"
- Accountability: "Accountability skills"
- M&E design and planning: "Improved logical framework development"
- M&E implementation: "Implementing monitoring and evaluation systems"
- Evaluation: "Conducting evaluation of projects/programmes"
- Monitoring: "Monitoring design"
- Methodological skills for evaluation: "Impact evaluation methodology"
- Risk management: "Risk management"
- Project management: "Management skills"
- Stakeholder analysis: "Better understanding of how to make practical linkages between project-level results and corporate, donor, or UN/SDG objectives"

- Stakeholder management: “Stakeholder management”
- Knowledge management: “Improved knowledge management”
- Tools selection, use, and design: “Build SMART indicators (with baselines/targets)”
- Budgeting: “Resource planning”

Results show that the most represented categories – and skills - in the data were that of M&E design and planning,;Project design; Reporting; tools selection, use and design; data analysis; data collection; M&E implementation; Transform data into actionable insights; risk managment; evaluation.

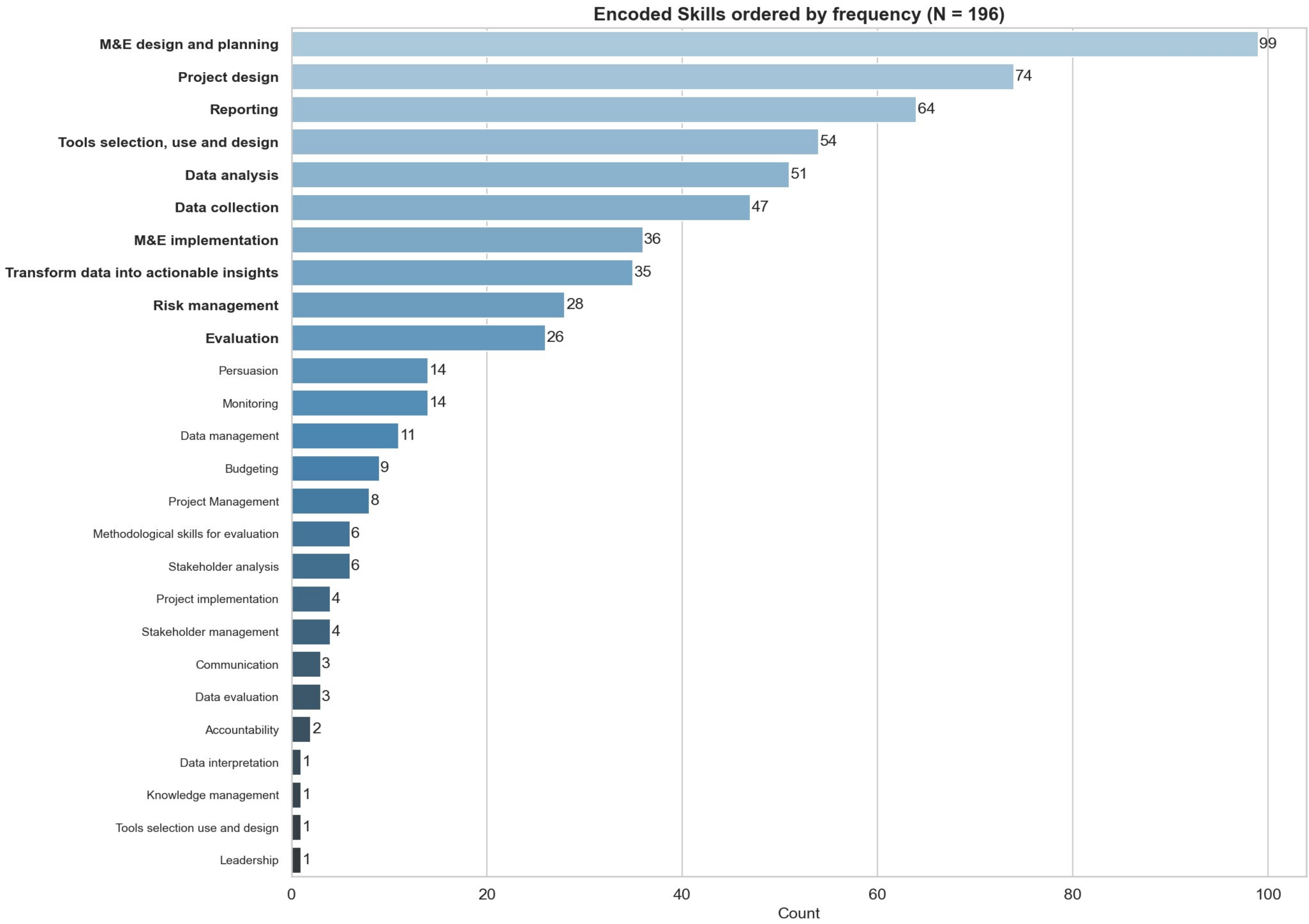
See below for a visual representation of the skills in order of freqency in the data (N =196).

After a careful reading of the categories, and using the framework offered by the ongoing certification programme, the categories have been organized into six meaningful themes:

- Project management: skills referring to project design and roles;
- M&E core: skills referring to high-level monitoring and evaluation processes and activities;
- Data and analysis: skills referring to data, from collection to interpretation and evaluation of its quality;
- Knowledge and insights: skills referring to the use of data to improve decision-making at the project level;
- Stakeholders and dissemination of insights: skills referring to the communication of results, advocacy for M&E, needs analysis and management, and accountability to donors;
- Tools and methods: skills referring to tools—from indicators to matrices—and methodology.

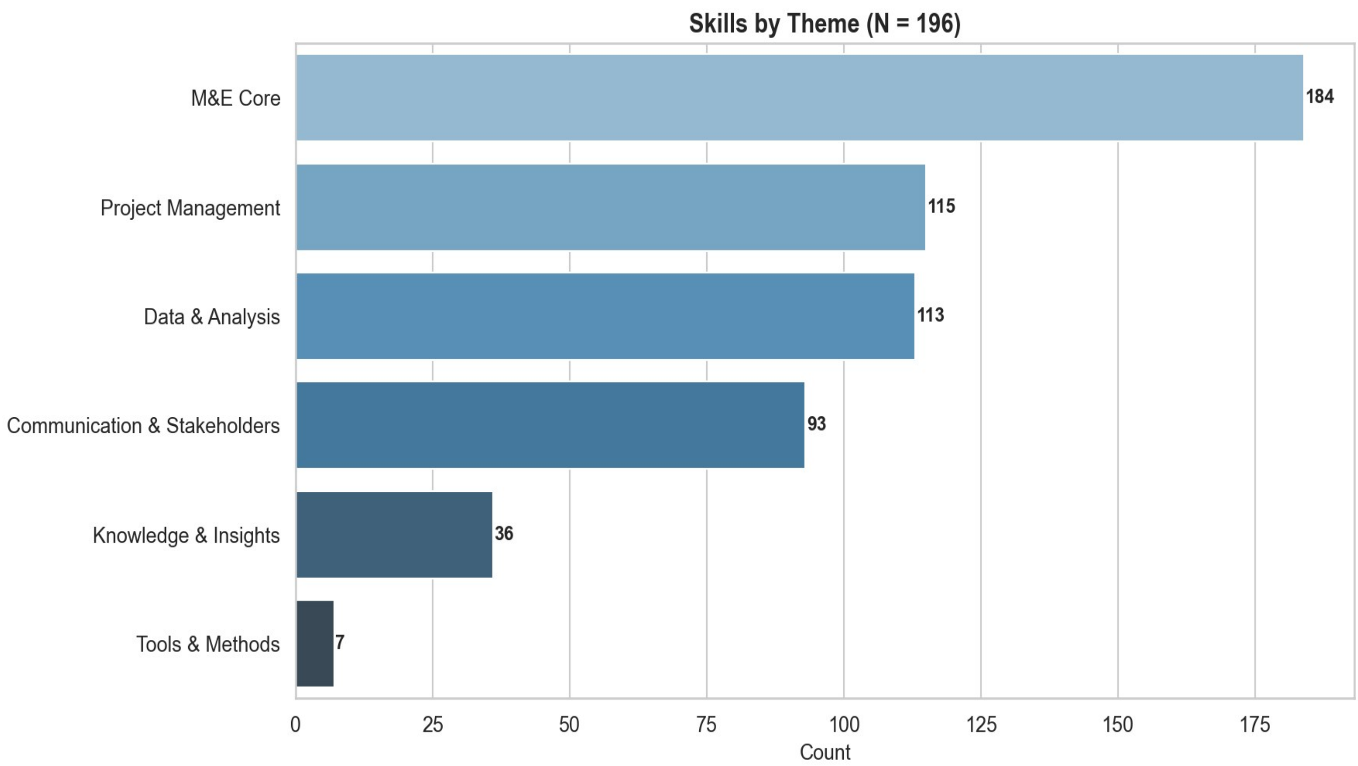
Finally, after counting how many times each category was cited in the data, it emerged that the three most frequently mentioned themes were M&E core skills, project management skills, and data and analysis skills.

In conclusion, most participants in the 2025 cohort of the M&E Certification Programme took part in the programme with the aim of acquiring or strengthening their skills in core M&E processes and activities (e.g., planning and implementing M&E systems), project management (especially the design of logical frameworks and theories of change), and data and analysis skills, with the most frequently cited skills being planning an M&E system, project design, and reporting to stakeholders.


Encoded Skills ordered by frequency (N = 196)
M&E design and planning
Project design
Reporting
Tools selection, use and design
Data analysis
Data collection
M&E implementation
Transform data into actionable insights
Risk management
Evaluation
Persuasion
Monitoring
Data management
Budgeting
Project Management
Methodological skills for evaluation
Stakeholder analysis
Project implementation
Stakeholder management
Communication
Data evaluation
Accountability
Data interpretation
Knowledge management
Tools selection use and design
Leadership
99
74
64
54
51
47
36
35
28
26
14
14
11
9
8
6
6
4
4
3
3
2
1
1
1
1
0
20
40
60
80
100
Count

Themes emerged

Project Management	• Project design • Project Management • Project implementation • Risk management • Leadership
M&E Core	• M&E design and planning • M&E implementation • Monitoring • Evaluation • Budgeting
Data & Analysis	• Data analysis • Data collection • Data management • Data interpretation • Data evaluation
Knowledge and Insights	• Transform data into actionable insights • Knowledge management
Stakeholders and dissemination of findings	• Communication • Reporting • Stakeholder analysis • Stakeholder management • Persuasion • Accountability
Tools & Methods	• Tools selection use and design • Methodological skills for evaluation



Conclusions

The current report highlights the absence of evidence to support the existence of gender differences in the experience of M&E, which is overall perceived by participants as positive or mixed.

Moreover, a systematic and thorough approach to risk appears to be mostly adopted in UN organizations, international organizations, and consultancies, and the size of the project does not appear to be a determining factor in its adoption. The data also show that an undocumented approach to risk management is too often used. This type of management limits the possibility of learning from mistakes and of being attentive to critical issues that may emerge during project implementation, particularly in larger organizations and in the case of large-scale programmes.

Finally, participants in the programme indicate that project design, data, and reporting to stakeholders are the main factors motivating participation in the course, reflecting a general dissatisfaction with training in these areas in other contexts.